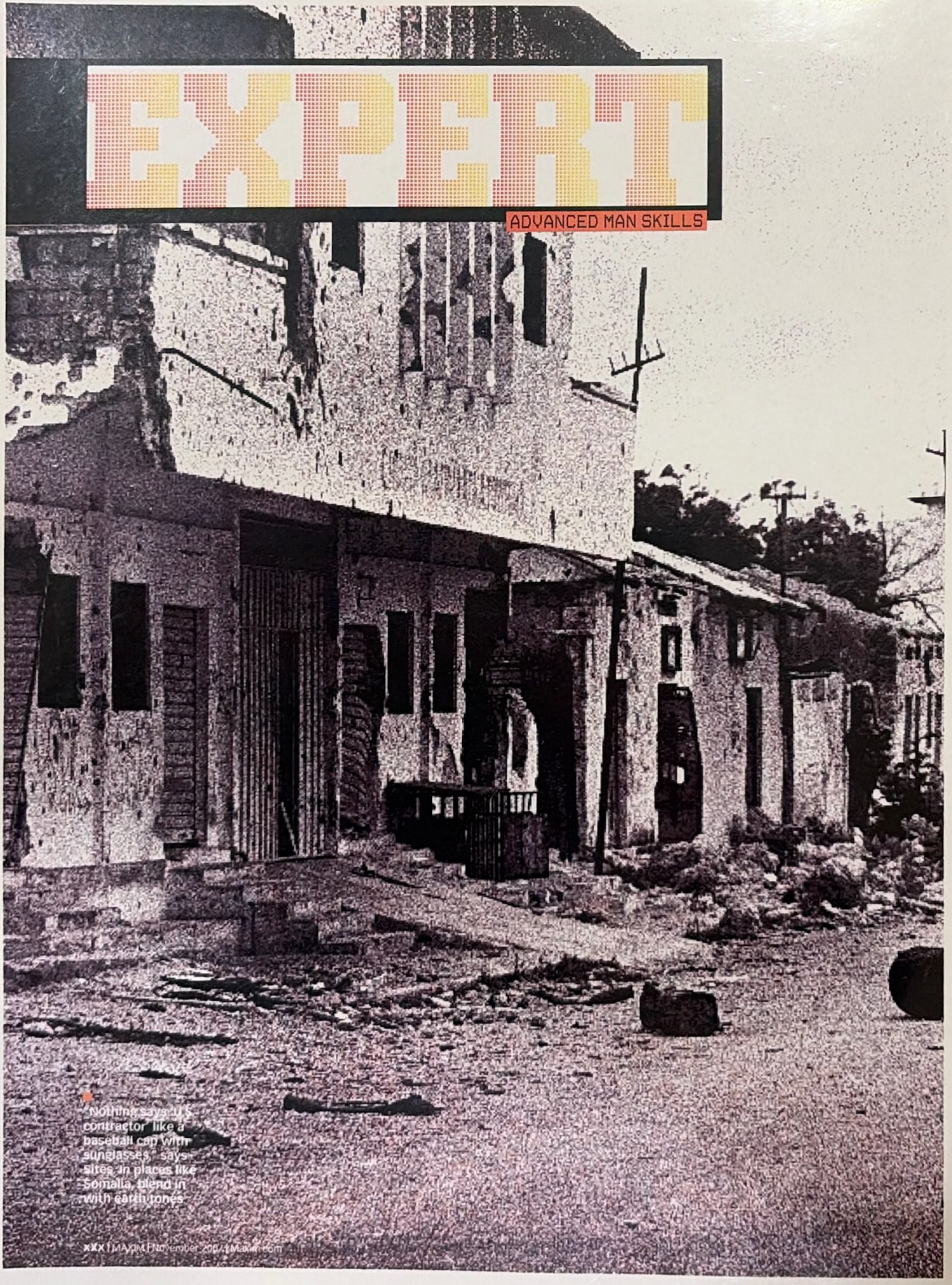
EXPERT

ADVANCED MAN SKILLS



"Nothing says U.S. contractor like a baseball cap with sunglasses," says Sifter. In places like Somalia, blend in with earth tones

How to Visit a Danger Zone

Headed somewhere sketchy? War journalist Kevin Sites visited 19 global hot spots in 12 months. Listen up and survive trouble abroad.

1

Get Drugged Up
If there's a war in progress, forget about dropping by the hospital for a quick checkup. "Be prepared to support yourself medically," advises Sites. "Yellow fever, hepatitis, malaria—get the immunizations before you go and know your blood type just in case." To knock out travelers' diarrhea and bacterial infections, carry a broad-spectrum antibiotic like Cipro.

2

Find a "Fixer"
You'll need a well-connected guide who knows the language and customs, so use any means necessary (travel blogs, friends of friends) to book one before you leave. "It should be someone you can trust, but also someone who's an operator," says Sites. "He'll need to pull some strings if you want to move around freely." The peace of mind you'll gain at checkpoints alone is worth it, even at $100 per day (the global average).

3

Be Hyperaware
Whether you're alone in your room or mashed against hundreds of locals on the street, keep your head on a swivel. "Know your escape routes," Sites advises. "Does the hotel have another exit? Are there side streets you can duck down?" If you're entering a volatile situation, it's important to appear as laid-back and unassuming as possible. "It sounds funny, but short hair is associated with the military in many of these places," says Sites. "It doesn't hurt to skip the pretrip haircut."

4

Have Street Smarts
"You can't just pop into an Internet café in a war-torn country," notes Sites. If possible, travel with a satellite phone and a solar charger—not merely for communication, but also for bartering purposes: "Let somebody make a call and you'll build trust." While you're at it, keep trinkets on hand. Sometimes something as small as handing out a pen can buy you a big favor.

Text: Jeff Edds

Read about Sites' close calls in Colombia, Iraq, Afghanistan, and almost everywhere else in his book, *In the Hot Zone*.

Kevin Sites